GUEST COLUMN | *CONSENT, CHOICE AND THE LIMITS OF LOVE*



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THE GAP BETWEEN KNOWING AND DOING

Viral awareness has transformed public discourse, but meaningful change requires consent to become a culture rooted in equality and dignity



Consent discourse, as we term it today, emerged in the 1970s, primarily in the US. Analyses of gender-based violence unpacked the material, emotional, cultural and bodily control of women through patriarchy, leading to a new understanding of bodily autonomy. The phrase 'no means no' appeared in this context. As the idea of female desire came into sharper focus, consent too evolved from refusal, or 'no means no', to expressed desire and affirmative consent, or 'yes means yes'.

In India, this discourse emerged at a more particular juncture. The protests following the Delhi gang rape of 2012 brought diverse groups of people, many without experience of political engagement, on to the streets, and moved the question of sexual violence to the front pages. Notably, this may well have been the first public protest movement to transition from the streets to the internet, coinciding with the rise of social media.

Social media's power to transmit messages to incredibly large numbers at speed, and its tools for quick creativity and campaign-building, were invigorating. It became a space for raising conversations and building connection. A number of initiatives and accounts focused on gender and sexuality proliferated. When #MeToo arrived, they were able to leverage these digital resources to sustain the issues. Consent discourse grew rapidly in these years. The story of this digital success, as well as its limitations, illuminates the overarching finding of the INDIA TODAY consent survey: that there is a significant gap between women's awareness of consent and their actual experience of it.

Consent discourse, with its clear messaging of 'no means no' and 'yes means yes', was well suited to the conditions for social media virality. To gain traction, a message must conform to social media formats: small word counts, short videos and a simple, preferably one-point message, repeated often, as in advertising. When Amitabh Bachchan thundered 'no means no' in the courtroom drama *Pink* (2016), it was celebrated as the mainstream penetration of a feminist message.

Consent discourse, boiled down to its basics, could be 'scaled up' by numerous players—from brands to NGOs to influencers—because in its common minimum form, no one will disagree with it. But is the bare minimum enough to imagine freedom?

Social media numbers validate impact and make it feel like a politically fertile space. By delinking consent from other structural questions of autonomy and equality, it enabled the wide acceptance of consent as a 'gender product', or a